

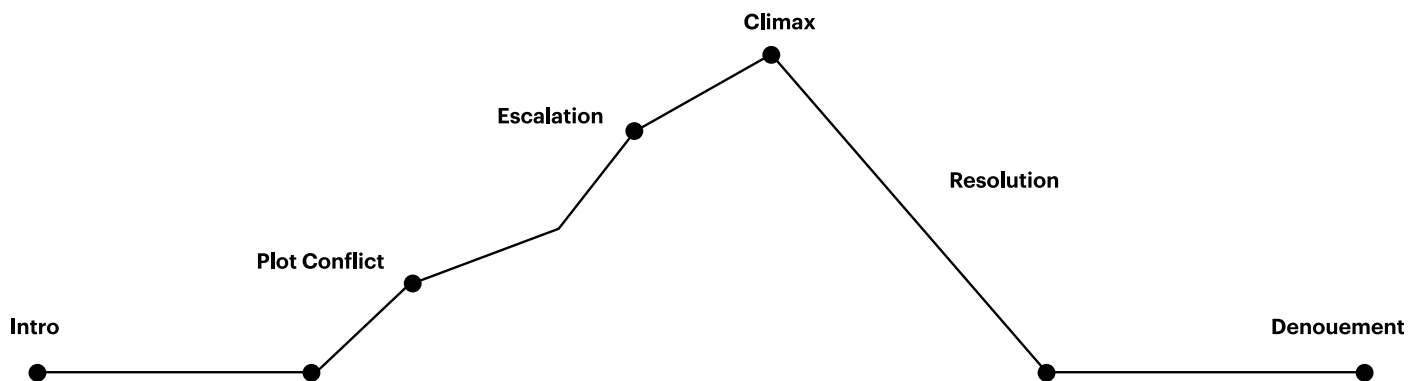
Session 19: Plot in Biblical Narrative: The Story of Jonah

Key Takeaways

- The plot of a narrative invests the story with meaning—the conflict within a plot and how the conflict is resolved invests the narrative with its ethical message.
- Narrative meaning can also be found through plot sequence, or the use of conflict, climax, and resolution to convey a message. The same characters in the same conflict but with different resolutions of the climax can have a different message.

Keys for Interpreting Biblical Narrative: Plot

Plot is the arrangement of characters and events into a meaningful sequence in order to communicate the meaning of the story.



Plot Structure. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

“Stories and plots are the crucial agents that invest events with meaning. The way the facts are described, the point at which the tension is created and the climax occurs, the selection and arrangement of the parts, these all indicate the meaning which the events are believed to possess, and thus what an author means to communicate by telling them to the reader.”

Wright, N.T. (1992). [*The New Testament and the People of God*](#). Fortress Press. 79.

Narrative Meaning and Plot Sequence

Narratives communicate by identifying a particular event as the problem that ignites tension and forces the characters into a story of finding a resolution. With the selection of the problem and the way characters overcome it and find a solution, these plot points assume and manifest the narrator's ethical value set, and they are part of how stories make moral claims on the reader.

The same exact series of events can carry a totally different moral message based on the chosen plot conflict and resolution.

- Story #1: Billy is a growing young boy. He keeps sneaking cookies from the cupboards at night. His mom keeps catching him, and so he develops more and more creative ways to steal the cookies.
- Story #2: Billy is a growing young boy. He keeps sneaking cookies from the cupboards at night. His mom gets more and more concerned, and eventually develops a reward system so that if he cleans his room weekly he can earn lots of cookies.

Tracking the Plot: Jonah

Reading biblical narrative requires the developed skill of tracking the plot so that we get the message intended by the author.

Let's look at the story of Jonah. What is the real plot conflict?

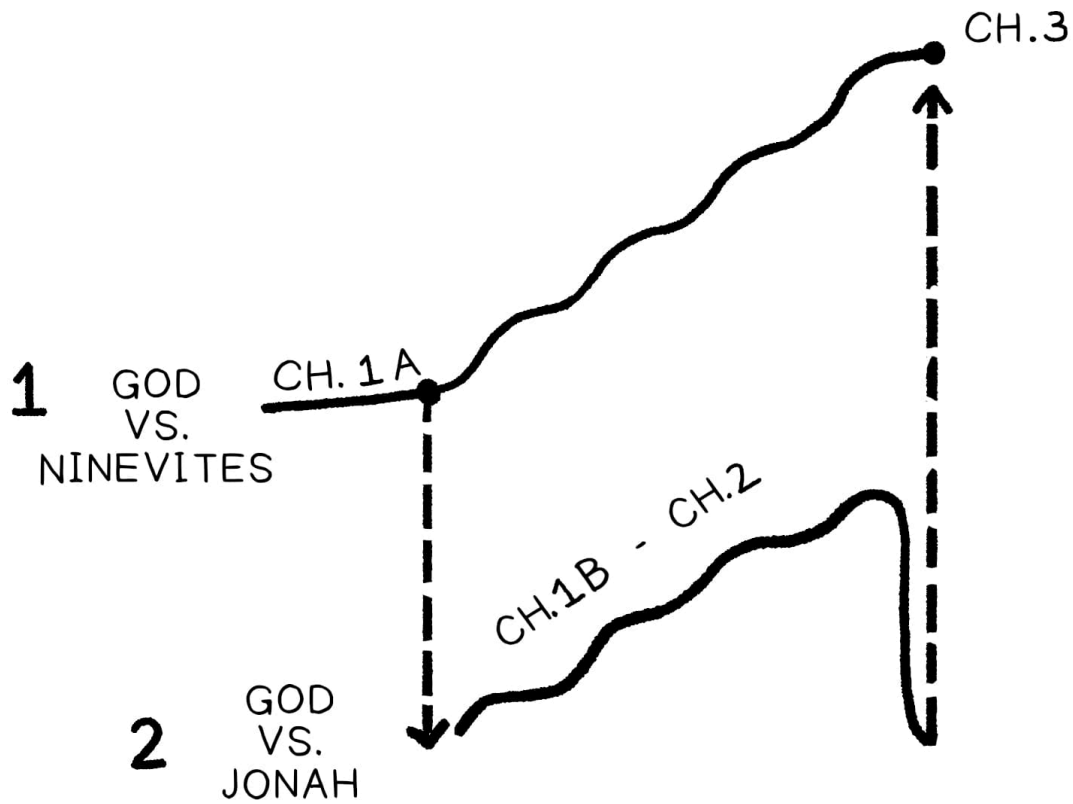
In Jonah 1, we are presented two plot conflicts:

1. God and Nineveh: The word of Yahweh came to Jonah, "Arise, go to Nineveh the great city and cry against it, for their wickedness has come up before me." (1:1-2)
2. God and Jonah: "But Jonah rose up to flee to Tarshish from the presence of the Lord." (1:3)

In Jonah 2, the second plot conflict is addressed as Jonah nears death, prays to God, and is delivered.

In Jonah 3, the first plot conflict is addressed as the Ninevites turn away from their evil after Jonah's message.

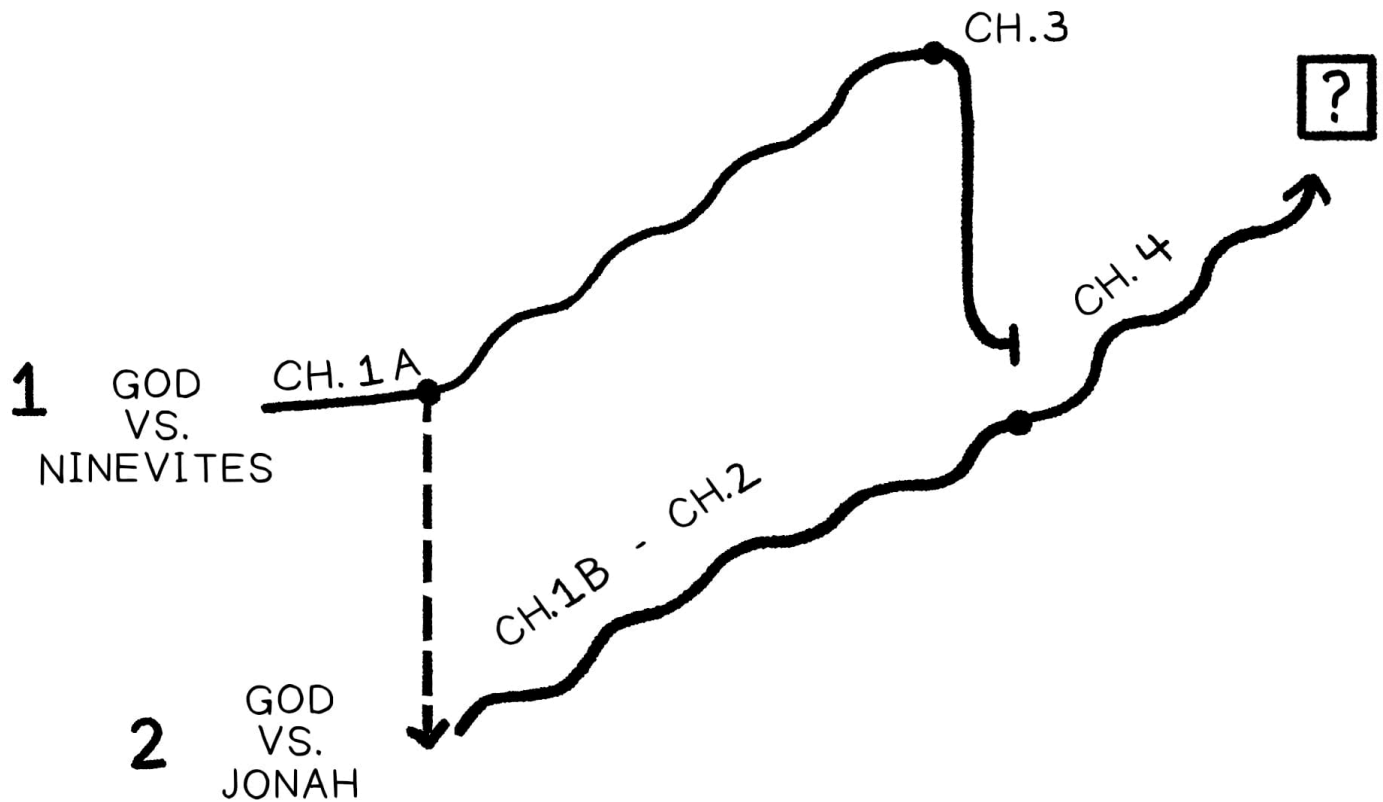
If the story ended in chapter 3 (as it does in many children's books), it would be a nice and neat story: People should turn away from their evil (like the Ninevites) and rebellion (like Jonah) and obey God.



Jonah Plot Through Chapter 3. Diagram created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

But Jonah chapter 4 problematizes all this! Here we find out that while Jonah has technically obeyed, he still harbors anger, resentment, and contempt for God. In other words, plot conflict #2 was never really resolved, and the book ends with that conflict up in the air.

The four-chapter book is about how God's own people can become the biggest obstacle to God's purposes in the world!



Jonah Plot Through Chapter 4. Diagram created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

Overlapping Plotlines: Abraham

Biblical stories consist of multiple overlapping plotlines. The reader must distinguish between the overall plotline and the many subplots that make up the “episodes” of a larger story. But not only that, the lower-level plotlines all connect with and contribute to the bigger plotline.

This time, let’s look at the way plotlines overlap in the story of Abraham. Start with the question, “What is the plot conflict?”

Genesis 12:1-3: God calls Abraham to an act of radical faith so that the divine blessing can be restored to all the nations through him.

Potential plot conflict: “Those who bless you, I will bless, and those who curse you I will curse. And all the families of the land will find blessing through you” (Gen. 12:3).

Genesis 12:4-9: Abraham obeys and goes to Canaan!

Genesis 12:10-20: Abraham lacks faith and leaves the land, and he then lies about his wife, placing her in danger of being taken by other men. God then brings death plagues on Pharaoh’s house. Abraham's lack of faith brings a curse and not blessing on the nations. So Pharaoh gives him wealth and slaves, and sends him back to Canaan.

Genesis 15: God promises Abraham that a child will come from his body and not another, and this descendant will become God's blessing to the nations.

Genesis 16: Sarah and Abraham sexually abuse Hagar, an Egyptian slave, in an effort to produce a son by their own wisdom, resulting in the birth of Ishmael.

Genesis 21: Abraham and Sarah have their own child, Isaac, and Sarah jealously exiles Hagar and Ishmael. So Abraham abandons them to their fate by sending them out into the desert with a small amount of water. He loses his firstborn son.

Genesis 22: God "tests" Abraham by demanding back the life of his beloved son. Abraham finally surrenders his most precious and valued son, and God spares him by providing a substitute (the ram). This is why God says he will fulfill his promise from Genesis 12:3 (see Gen. 22:15-18).

As we trace the plot conflict through the Abraham story, we see how the biblical author has set up the questions driving the narrative forward. The overarching plot conflict of Genesis 12-22 is created by God's choice of Abraham. God has committed to spreading his divine blessing to all nations through this man and his wife. But Abraham and Sarah actually become the problem that God has to overcome!

"The very first, and only really rigid, rule in literary theory is that texts must be read from beginning to end. The meaning of a word is not determined by its definition, but by its context. So also a single story's meaning is only determined by the relationship of all its elements to the whole text."

McEvenue, Sean (1994). [*Interpretation and Bible: Essays on Truth in Literature*](#). Liturgical Press. 171.

Reflection Question

What are some of your main takeaways from this discussion on biblical plot and subplot in the book of Jonah?